

Slow and steady fire
A royalist regiment unleashes a volley of musket fire *(above)*. The uniforms and weapons of the two sides in the English Civil War were remarkably similar. Because the matchlock musket *(right)* was still very inaccurate and took a long time to reload, the musketeers always had to be protected by large bodies of pikemen.

THE ARMIES THAT FOUGHT in the civil wars in Britain between 1642 and 1651 were commanded by officers with experience of war in continental Europe. Their tactics and organization thus followed currently fashionable European models, in which well-drilled infantry armed with a mix of pikes and muskets were considered essential to battlefield success. But Britain had few men trained in the use of arms and it took years to create truly viable fighting forces, a process that reached its peak in the New Model Army.

At the heart of the complex series of conflicts that wreaked havoc in England, Scotland, and Ireland from 1642 onward was a political and religious confrontation between King Charles I and the English parliament. Many of those who fought in the civil wars were principled men with a sense of commitment to the royalist or parliamentarian cause. Yet from the outset there were also many soldiers who simply fought for whichever side happened to control the area they lived in; some fought for both sides at different times.



Bandolier
English musketeers carried measured powder charges in wooden flasks around their necks.

RAISING TROOPS

The bulk of the initial combatants in the civil wars were either volunteers or members of local militias (known as the "Trained Bands"). As the conflict dragged on, however, both sides had to raise levies to fill the ranks of their infantry, using a chaotic process of conscription that produced mostly poor quality troops from the lowest levels of society. Equipping and paying troops was a challenging task under the conditions of the time. With great effort, all soldiers in the civil wars were fitted out with basic weapons, shoes, and some kind of uniform. The uniforms were generally so diverse, however, that on the day of a battle soldiers would be issued with a special item to wear, such as a sash, to distinguish friend from foe. The soldiers' pay was normally heavily in arrears – a frequent cause of mutiny. Men often had to be paid some of the money they were owed before a battle or siege in order to get them to fight. Unpaid soldiers depended on pillage and the sacking of towns for the chance of gain.

A NEW ARMY

In 1645 the English parliament established the New Model Army in order to centralize the organization of its military forces, which had previously been raised and trained locally. It contained a strong core of ideologically committed officers and veterans who saw themselves as the "army of the Living God". It was unique in fitting out all its infantry in identical uniforms and it was also better than other civil war formations at paying its troops regularly. But it could not escape from the general conditions of armies of its day. As well as the dedicated core, the army contained many soldiers who had joined for the pay and adventure, or because as conscripts they had been given no choice. An officer, Colonel John Venn, complained that the levies he was sent were "men taken out of prison, tinkers, pedlars, and vagrants that have no dwelling". Such men had to be brought to the army under armed guard and many of them deserted at the very first opportunity. Nor did the new army always succeed in paying its troops on time, and its soldiers sought their own fortunes in traditional military fashion.



MATCHLOCK MUSKET